

Quick bites :

- ✓ Reading is a very important skill which helps in many ways like learning and comprehending complex material.
- ✓ Reading can be extensive or intensive based on the purpose of reading.
- ✓ Skimming is used to get an overview and understand the central idea of the material, while scanning is used to search for specific information.
- ✓ Fast reading is more effective than slow reading as it gives an overall perspective of the text rather than focussing on single word or sentence.
- ✓ Understanding the structure of the text helps in comprehension as it gives an idea about the change in the central idea of a paragraph.
- ✓ Reading headings and subheadings gives overall idea of the text.
- ✓ Paying attention to punctuation marks is important as they give a particular meaning to the text.
- ✓ Understanding author's viewpoint and being able to balance between one's own thoughts and author's perspective is important to truly understand a text.

Review Questions

1. Explain the difference between hearing and listening. (Refer section 5.1.2)
2. What are the barriers to effective listening ? (Refer section 5.1.4)
3. Explain the importance of listening. (Refer section 5.1.2)
4. What are the traits of a good listener ? (Refer section 5.1.5)
5. Give tips for effective listening. (Refer section 5.1.5)
6. What is the importance of reading ? (Refer section 5.2)
7. Explain different techniques for effective reading. (Refer section 5.3)
8. Give tips for improving reading skills. (Refer section 5.1.5)
9. Explain types of reading. (Refer section 5.2)
10. Write a note on : 1) Skimming, 2) Scanning. (Refer section 5.2)



Unit 6

6

Enhancing Language through Literature

Syllabus

The Red Rice Granary by Sudha Murty, The Gift of Magi by O. Henry, The World-Renowned Nose by V.M. Basheer, The Lady or, The Tiger? by Frank R. Stockton

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Learning objectives :

- To develop a love for different literary styles and themes.
- To improve critical thinking and interpretation skills through the use of narratives.
- To explore universal human emotions and values expressed in literature.
- To foster creative expression and personal reflection inspired by literary works.
- To enhance language proficiency through the exposure to rich and varied literary texts.

This unit is designed to develop linguistic and analytical abilities by exposing students to great literary works that reflect timelessness and speak to all humanity. Literature opens the window into human experiences, emotions, and cultures; in learning those from literary pieces, our world becomes richer. Through stories, besides developing vocabulary and comprehension, students sharpen their powers of critical thinking and interpretation.

This unit contains four interesting stories in which the central themes include love, sacrifice, societal perceptions, and moral dilemmas. The story is something that provides each reader with the opportunity to enjoy this art of narration while further developing intimacy with language and its expression power.

6.1 The Red Rice Granary by Sudha Murty

About the Author

Sudha Murty was born in 1950. She is an Indian author, educator, and philanthropist, recognized for her pioneering contributions to computer science and engineering, as well as for the social work she has done, which has positively impacted society. She received the prestigious Padma Shri award in 2006 for her philanthropic efforts. As a writer, she has been incredibly prolific, filling readers' hearts with insight and warmth through her books. Known for her humility and unwavering commitment to service, she inspires millions through her work and writings.

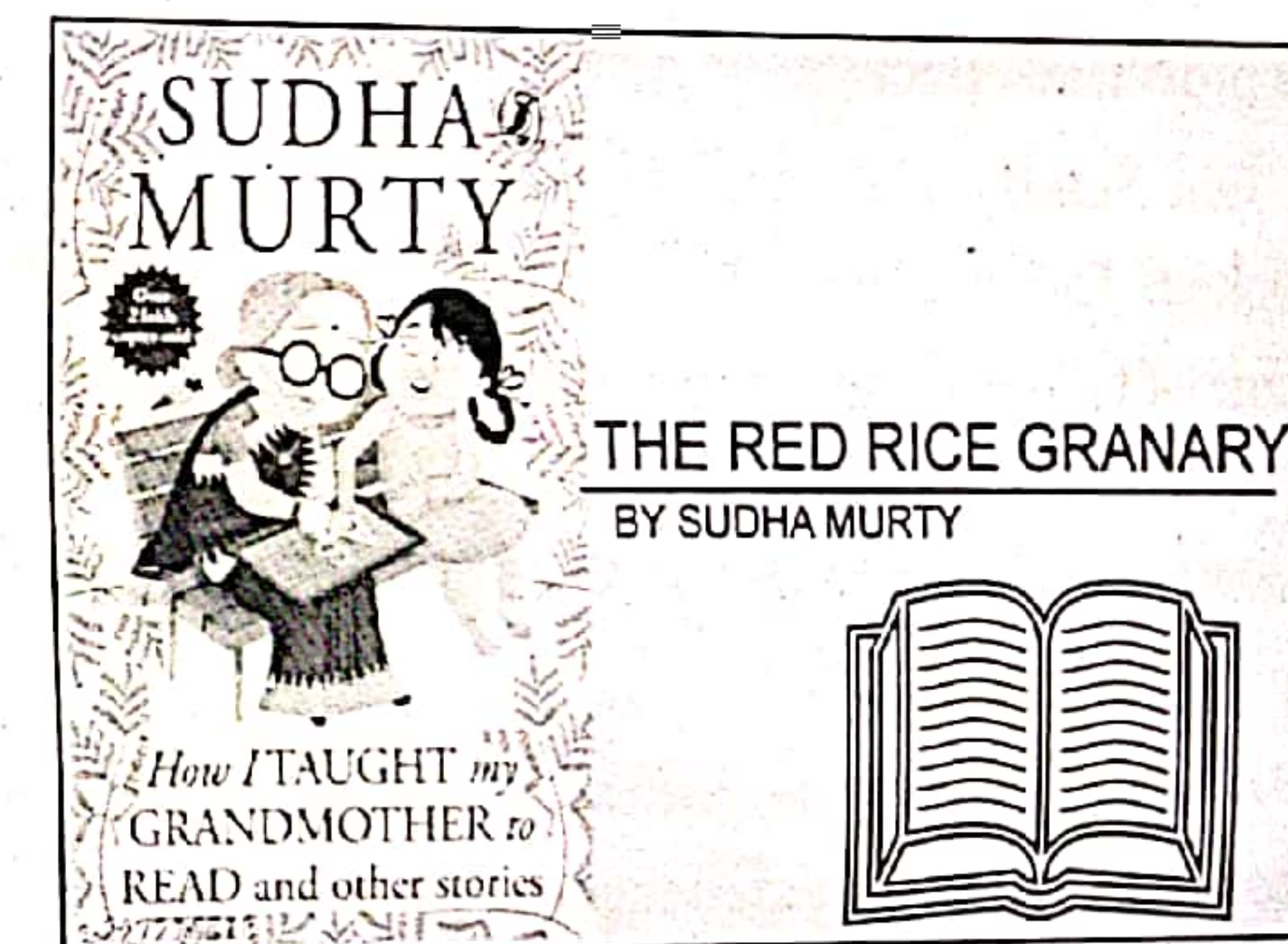


Sudha Murty

Her works often draw inspiration from Indian culture, traditions, and values, reflecting her deep connection to rural life and societal issues. Beyond her literary contributions, Sudha Murty is the chairperson of the Infosys Foundation, which focuses on education, healthcare, and rural development in India.

➤ The Red Rice Granary Summary

Sudha Murty's story has themes of generosity, rural life, and the value of tradition. The story revolves around a granary in a small village where surplus rice is stored to feed the needy in bad times. The granary, if managed with trust and communal spirit, reflects the values of unity and charity behind the ethos of the rural Indian heart. Through a touching storyline, Murty explores the impact of these traditional practices on individuals and the community.



The Red Rice Granary full story

Every year, our country has to face natural disasters in some form. It may be an earthquake in Gujarat, floods in Orissa or a drought in Karnataka. In a poor country, these calamities create havoc.

In the course of my work, I have found that after such calamities, many people like to donate money or materials to relief funds. We assume that most donations come from rich people, but that is not true. On the contrary, people from the middle class and lower middle class help more. Rarely do rich people participate wholeheartedly.

A few years back, I was invited to a reputed company in Bangalore to deliver a lecture on Corporate Social Responsibility. Giving a speech is easy. But I was not sure how many people in the audience would really understand the speech and change themselves.

After my talk was over, I met many young girls and boys. It was an affluent company and the employees were well off and well-dressed. They were all very emotional after the lecture.

'Madam, we buy so many clothes every month. Can we donate our old clothes to those people who are affected by the earthquake? Can you coordinate and send them?'

Some of them offered other things- 'We have grown-up children, we would like to give their old toys and some vessels.'

I was very pleased at the reaction. It reminded me of the incident in Ramayana where during the construction of the bridge between India and Lanka, every squirrel helped Shri Rama by bringing a handful of sand.

Please send your bags to my office. I will see that they reach the right people."

Within a week, my office was flooded with hundreds of bags. I was proud that my lecture had proven so effective.

One Sunday, along with my assistants, I opened the bags. What we saw left us amazed and shocked. The bags were brimming over with all kinds of junk! Piles of high heeled slippers (some of them without the pair), torn undergarments, unwashed shirts, transparent, cheap saris, toys which had neither shape nor colour, unusable bed sheets, aluminium vessels, broken cassettes were soon heaped in front of us like a mountain. There were only a few good shirts, saris and usable materials.

It was apparent that, instead of sending the material to the garbage or the kabadiwala, these people had transferred them to my office in the name of donation. The men and women I had met that day were bright, well travelled, well-off people. If educated people like them behaved like this, what would uneducated people do?

But then I was reminded of an incident from my childhood. I was born and brought up in a village in Karnataka's Haveri district, called Shiggaon. My grandfather was a retired school teacher and my grandmother Krishtakka never went to school. Both of them had hardly travelled and had never stepped out of Karnataka. Yet they were hardworking people, who did their work wholeheartedly without expecting anything from anybody in their life. Their photographs never appeared in any paper, nor did they go up on a stage to receive a prize for the work they did. They lived like flowers with fragrance in the forest, enchanting everyone around them, but hardly noticed by the outside world.

In the village we had paddy fields and we used to store the paddy in granaries. There were two granaries. One was in the front and the other at the back of our house. The better quality rice, which was white, was always stored in the front granary and the inferior quality, which was a little thick and red, was stored in the granary at the back.

In those days, there was no communal divide in the village. People from different communities lived together in peace. Many would come to our house to ask for alms. There were Muslim Fakirs, Hindu Dasalahs who roamed the countryside singing devotional songs, Yellamma Jogathis who appeared holding the image of Goddess Yellamma over their heads, poor students and invalid people.

We never had too much cash in the house and the only help my grandfather could give these people was in the form of rice. People who receive help do not talk too much. They would receive the rice, smile and raise their right hand to bless us. Irrespective of their religion, the blessing was always "May God bless you." My grandfather always looked happy after giving them alms.

I was a little girl then and not too tall. Since the entrance to the front granary was low, it was difficult for grown-ups to enter. So I would be given a small bucket and sent inside. There I used to fill up the bucket with rice and give it to them. They would tell me how many measures they wanted.

In the evening, my grandmother used to cook for everybody. That time she would send me to the granary at the back of the house where the red rice was stored. I would again fill up the bucket with as much rice as she wanted and get it for her to cook our dinner.

This went on for many years. When I was a little older, I asked my grandparents a question that had been bothering me for a long time.

'Why should we eat the red rice always at night when it is not so good, and give those poor - people better quality rice?'

My grandmother Krishtakka smiled and told me something I will never forget in my life.

"Child, whenever you want to give something to somebody, give the best in you, never the second best. That is what I have learned from life. God is not there in the temple, mosque or church. He is with the people. If you serve them with whatever you have, you have served God."

My grandfather answered my question in a different way.

Our ancestors have taught us in the Vedas that one should :

Donate with kind words.

Donate with happiness.

Donate with sincerity.

Donate only to the needy.

Donate without expectation because it is not a gift. It is a duty.

Donate with your wife's consent.

Donate to other people without making your dependents helpless.

Donate without caring for caste, creed and religion.

Donate so that the receiver prospers.

This lesson from my grandparents, told to me when I was just a little girl, has stayed with me ever since. If at all I am helping anyone today, it is because of the teachings by those simple souls; I did not learn them in any school or college.

➤ Themes

- Generosity** : The granary is a great metaphor for the act of giving. It depicts how communities can come together to share resources with those in need, illustrating the importance of charity and generosity in creating harmony and balance in society.
- Tradition vs. Modernity** : The story is an epitome of the conflict between the old selfless giving and the modern more selfish attitude. It reminds readers of the enduring value of traditional practices rooted in empathy and collective well-being.
- Empathy and Altruism** : The narrative brings out the need to understand and solve the problems of others. It teaches that service is from a place of selflessness, whereby help is offered without expecting anything in return.

➤ Character analysis

- Village elder** : The elder is the embodiment of wisdom and leadership. This character oversees the granary operations, symbolizing the values of fairness, humility, and unwavering commitment to communal welfare. His actions and decisions reflect the core principles of compassion and thoughtful charity.
- Protagonist** : The young villager is a personification of curiosity and growth. Through their relationship with the granary system and the elderly, they are taught life lessons about empathy, generosity, and the greater good. This character's journey mirrors the transformative power of understanding and adopting such values.

Review Questions

- When and where was Sudha Murty born?
- Sudha Murty is the chairperson of the Infosys Foundation, which focuses on education, arts, culture, and welfare.
- What prompted Sudha Murty to recall her childhood memories of the granary?
- Why were the narrator and her assistants shocked by the donations they received after the corporate lecture?
- How does the narrator's grandmother explain the importance of giving the best to others?

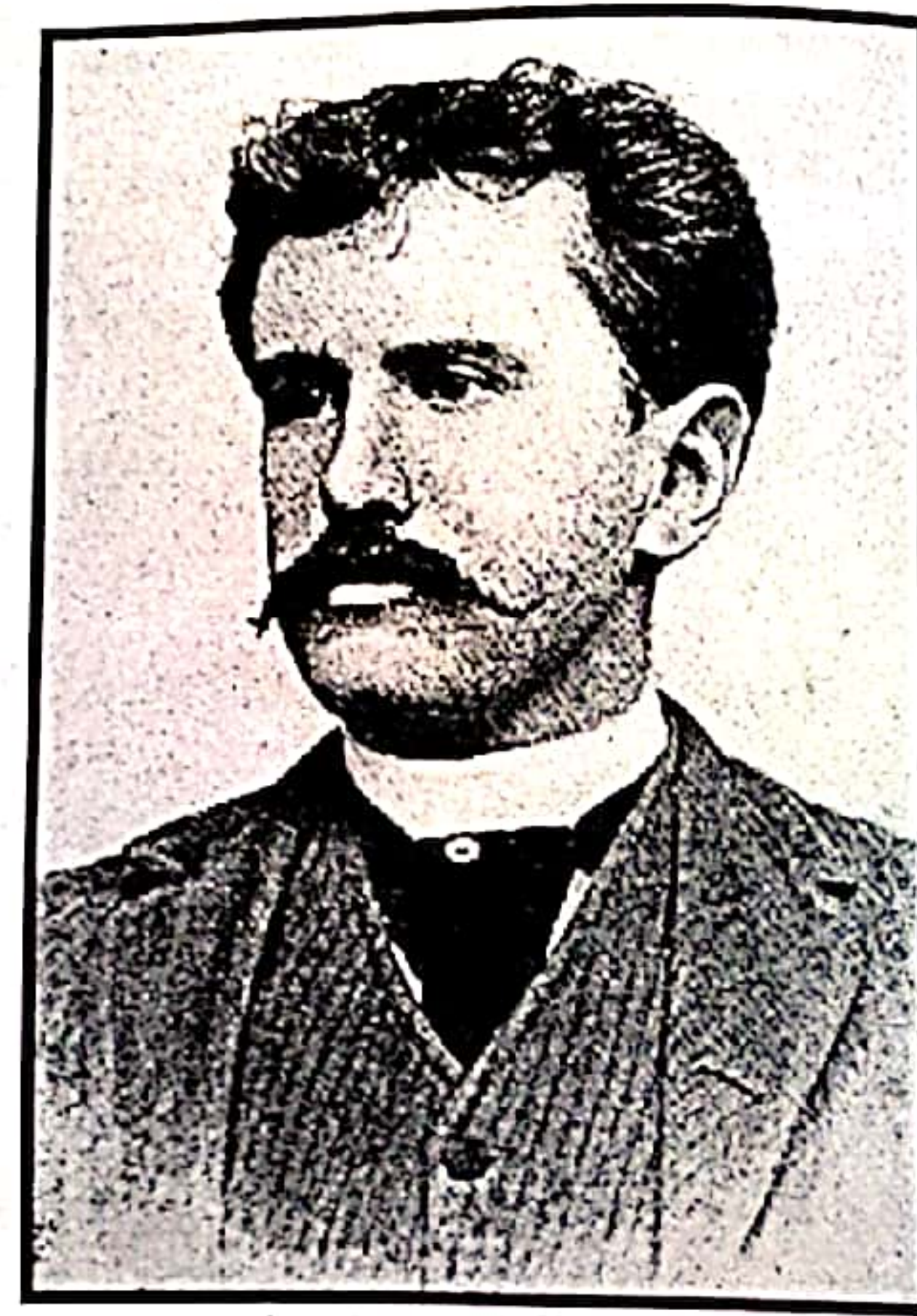
- What values did the narrator's grandparents teach her about donation and charity?
- What kind of values about donation and charity did the narrator's grandparents teach her?
- How does the granary in the village symbolize the spirit of unity and generosity?
- What contrast does the story draw between traditional and modern attitudes toward charity?
- Why did the narrator's family eat the red rice themselves while giving the better-quality rice to the needy?
- How does the story emphasize the idea that helping others is a duty rather than a gift?
- In what ways do the lessons of the narrator's grandparents reflect timeless moral and ethical principles?
- What message does Sudha Murty convey about the role of values in community building?
- Why did the narrator's grandparents donate the high-quality rice and reserve the red rice for themselves?
- What were the two granaries in the village? How much is each stored in units of rice?
- Reflect on the line, "Whenever you want to give something to somebody, give the best in you." How can this principle extend beyond material donations?
- If you were in the narrator's place, what would your response be to getting useless donations from wealthy people?

6.2 The Gift of the Magi by O. Henry

About the Author

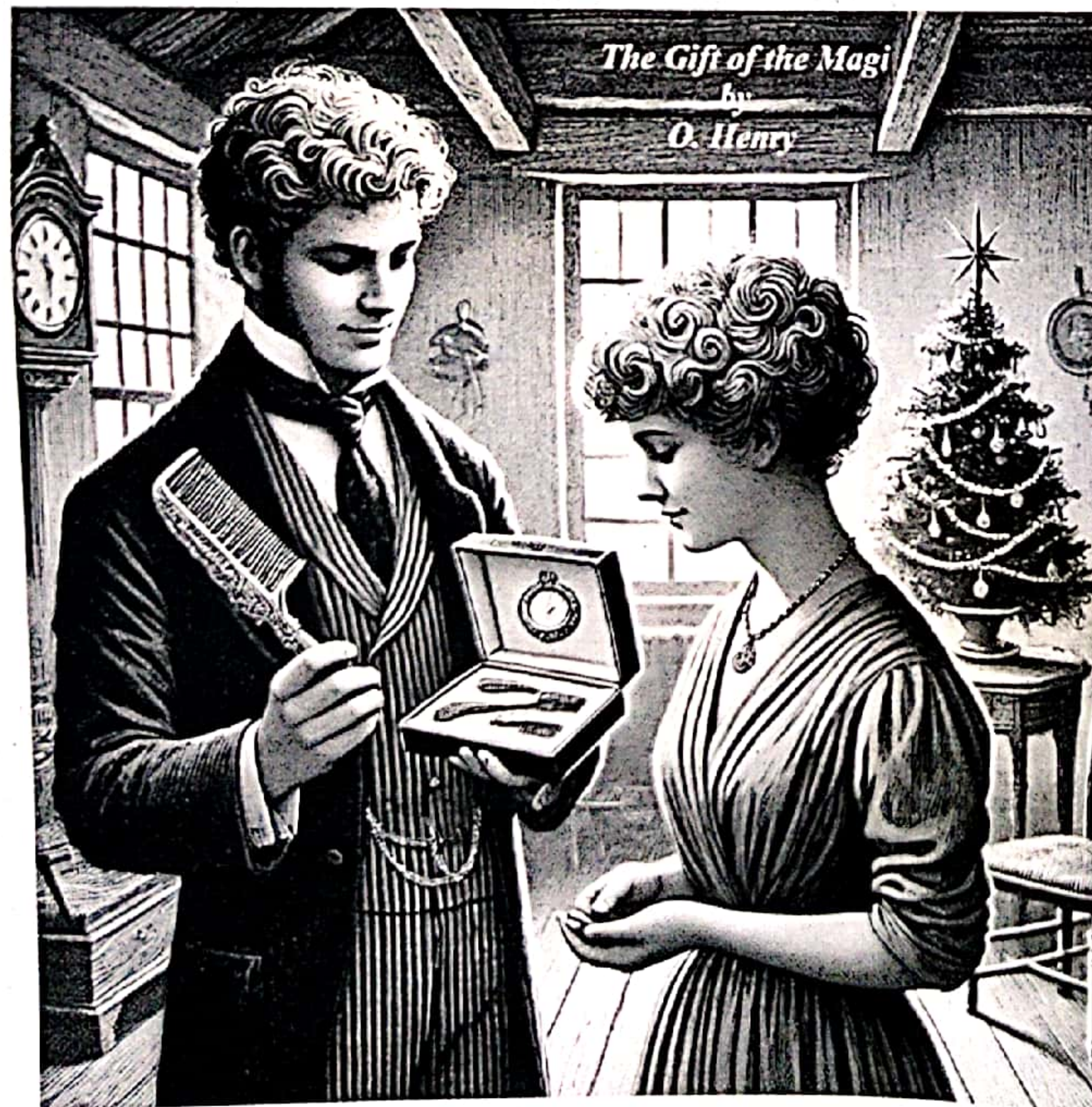
O. Henry, whose real name was William Sydney Porter (1862-1910), is known as one of the most popular and celebrated American short story writers, known for his wit, clever wordplay, and surprise endings. Born in North Carolina, such varied life experiences as a pharmacist, draftsman, and journalist are said to have influenced his style of storytelling.

His stories, as in *The Gift of the Magi*, *The Last Leaf*, and *The Ransom of Red Chief*, tell the attraction and challenge faced by ordinary man through the life-ironics twist. That is why O. Henry's works are an all-time favorite and the most precious of its kind in world literature.



O. Henry

➤ Summary of The Gift of the Magi



Della and Jim Dillingham Young are a young married couple who live in very modest conditions, struggling to make ends meet. The story begins with Della frantically counting her scarce savings of \$1.87 on Christmas Eve, trying to decide how to buy her husband an appropriate gift. Despite their difficult circumstances, Della is intent on giving Jim something special as a token of her deep love for him.

The couple has two prized possessions : Jim's gold pocket watch, a family heirloom, and Della's long, beautiful hair, which cascades like a shimmering waterfall. In a selfless act of love, Della decides to sell her hair to a shopkeeper for \$20 to buy Jim a platinum fob chain for his watch.

When Jim gets home that evening, he finds Della's new, short hairdo, and he is shocked. But his response is not one of anger or disappointment but of astonishment, for he reveals that he sold his treasured pocket watch to buy an exquisite set of combs Della had long admired for her hair.

The story culminates when the couple laughs in ironic understanding: both had made the most precious objects in their life temporarily unusable through selfless offerings to bring delight to the other. O. Henry compares this to the story of the Magi, the wise men who came with gifts to Jesus as a babe, stating that the love and sacrifice make the two the most brilliant gift givers.

The narrative poignantly celebrates love, sacrifice, and the true spirit of giving, highlighting the profound depth of selflessness in human relationships.

The Gift of Magi full story

ONE DOLLAR AND eighty-seven cents. That was all. And sixty cents of it was in pennies. Pennies saved one and two at a time by bulldozing the grocer and the vegetable man and the butcher until one's cheeks burned with the silent imputation of parsimony that such close dealing implied. Three times Della counted it. One dollar and eighty-seven cents. And the next day would be Christmas.

There was clearly nothing to do but flop down on the shabby little couch and howl. So Della did it. Which instigates the moral reflection that life is made up of sobs, sniffles, and smiles, with sniffles predominating.

While the mistress of the home is gradually subsiding from the first stage to the second, take a look at the home. A furnished flat at \$8 per week. It did not exactly beggar description, but it certainly had that word on the lookout for the mendicancy squad.

In the vestibule below was a letter-box into which no letter would go, and an electric button from which no mortal finger could coax a ring. Also appertaining thereunto was a card bearing the name "Mr. James Dillingham Young." The "Dillingham" had been flung to the breeze during a former period of prosperity when its possessor was being paid \$30 per week. Now, when the income was shrunk to \$20, the letters of "Dillingham" looked blurred, as though they were thinking seriously of contracting to a modest and unassuming D. But whenever Mr. James Dillingham Young came home and reached his flat above he was called "Jim" and greatly hugged by Mrs. James Dillingham Young, already introduced to you as Della. Which is all very good.

Della finished her cry and attended to her cheeks with the powder rag. She stood by the window and looked out dully at a grey cat walking a grey fence in a grey backyard. Tomorrow would be Christmas Day, and she had only \$1.87 with which to buy Jim a present. She had been saving every penny she could for months, with this result. Twenty dollars a week doesn't go far. Expenses had been greater than she had calculated. They always are. Only \$1.87 to buy a present for Jim. Her Jim. Many happy hours she had spent planning for something nice for him. Something fine and rare and sterling—something just a little bit near to being worthy of the honor of being owned by Jim.

There was a pier-glass between the windows of the room. Perhaps you have seen a pier-glass in an \$8 flat. A very thin and very agile person may, by observing his reflection in a rapid sequence of longitudinal strips, obtain a fairly accurate conception of his looks. Della, being slender, had mastered the art.

Suddenly she whirled from the window and stood before the glass. Her eyes were shining brilliantly, but her face had lost its color within twenty seconds. Rapidly she pulled down her hair and let it fall to its full length.

Now, there were two possessions of the James Dillingham Youngs in which they both took a mighty pride. One was Jim's gold watch that had been his father's and his grandfather's. The other was Della's hair. Had the Queen of Sheba lived in the flat across the airshaft, Della would have let her hair hang out the window some day to dry just to depreciate Her Majesty's jewels and gifts. Had King Solomon been the janitor, with all his treasures piled up in the basement, Jim would have pulled out his watch every time he passed, just to see him pluck at his beard from envy.

So now Della's beautiful hair fell about her, rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters. It reached below her knee and made itself almost a garment for her. And then she did it up again nervously and quickly. Once she faltered for a minute and stood still while a tear or two splashed on the worn red carpet.

On went her old brown jacket; on went her old brown hat. With a whirl of skirts and with the brilliant sparkle still in her eyes, she fluttered out the door and down the stairs to the street.

Where she stopped the sign read: "Mme. Sofronie. Hair Goods of All Kinds." One flight up Della ran, and collected herself, panting. Madame, large, too white, chilly, hardly looked at the "Sofronie."

"Will you buy my hair?" asked Della.

"I buy hair," said Madame. "Take yer hat off and let's have a sight at the looks of it."

Down rippled the brown cascade. "Twenty dollars," said Madame, lifting the mass with a practiced hand.

"Give it to me quick," said Della.

Oh, and the next two hours I tripped by on rosy wings. Forget the hashed metaphor. She was ransacking the stores for Jim's present.

She found it at last. It surely had been made for Jim and no one else. There was no other like it in any of the stores, and she had turned all of them inside out. It was a platinum fob chain simple and chaste in design, properly proclaiming its value by substance alone and not by meretricious ornamentation—as all good things should do. It was even worthy of The Watch. As soon as she saw it she knew that it must be Jim's. It was like him. Quietness and value—the description applied to both. Twenty-one dollars they took from her for it, and she hurried home with the 87 cents. With that chain on his watch Jim might be properly anxious about the time in any company. Grand as the watch was, he sometimes looked at it on the sly on account of the old leather strap that he used in place of a chain.

When Della reached home her intoxication gave way to prudence and reason. She got out her curling irons and lighted the gas and went to work repairing the ravages made by generosity added to love. Which is always a tremendous task, dear friends—a mammoth task.

Within forty minutes her head was covered with tiny, close-lying curls that made her look wonderfully like a truant schoolboy. She looked at her reflection in the mirror long, carefully, and critically.

"If Jim doesn't kill me," she said to herself, "before he takes a second look at me, he'll say I look like a Coney Island chorus girl. But what could I do—oh! what could I do with a dollar and eighty-seven cents?"

At 7 o'clock the coffee was made and the frying-pan was on the back of the stove hot and ready to cook the chops.

Jim was never late. Della doubled the fob chain in her hand and sat on the corner of the table near the door that he always entered. Then she heard his step on the stair away down on

the first flight, and she turned white for just a moment. She had a habit of saying little silent prayers about the simplest everyday things, and now she whispered: "Please God, make him think I am still pretty."

The door opened and Jim stepped in and closed it. He looked thin and very serious. Poor fellow, he was only twenty-two—and to be burdened with a family! He needed a new overcoat and he was without gloves.

Jim stopped inside the door, as immovable as a setter at the scent of quail. His eyes were fixed upon Della, and there was an expression in them that she could not read, and it terrified her. It was not anger, nor surprise, nor disapproval, nor horror, nor any of the sentiments that she had been prepared for. He simply stared at her fixedly with that peculiar expression on his face.

Della wriggled off the table and went for him.

"Jim, darling," she cried, "don't look at me that way. I had my hair cut off and sold it because I couldn't have lived through Christmas without giving you a present. It'll grow out again—you won't mind, will you? I just had to do it. My hair grows awfully fast. Say 'Merry Christmas!' Jim, and let's be happy. You don't know what a nice—what a beautiful, nice gift I've got for you."

"You've cut off your hair?" asked Jim, laboriously, as if he had not arrived at that patent fact yet even after the hardest mental labor.

"Cut it off and sold it," said Della. "Don't you like me just as well, anyhow? I'm me without my hair, ain't I?"

Jim looked about the room curiously.

"You say your hair is gone?" he said, with an air of almost idiocy.

"You needn't look for it," said Della. "It's sold, I tell you—sold and gone, too. It's Christmas Eve, boy. Be good to me, for it went for you. Maybe the hairs of my head were numbered," she went on with sudden serious sweetness, "but nobody could ever count my love for you. Shall I put the chops on, Jim?"

Out of his trance Jim seemed to quickly wake. He enfolded his Della. For ten seconds let us regard with discreet scrutiny some inconsequential object in the other direction. Eight dollars a week or a million a year—what is the difference? A mathematician or a wit would give you the wrong answer. The magi brought valuable gifts, but that was not among them. This dark assertion will be illuminated later on.

Jim drew a package from his overcoat pocket and threw it upon the table.

"Don't make any mistake, Dell," he said, "about me. I don't think there's anything in the way of a haircut or a shave or a shampoo that could make me like my girl any less. But if you unwrap that package you may see why you had me going a while at first."

White fingers and nimble tore at the string and paper. And then an ecstatic scream of joy; and then, alas! a quick feminine change to hysterical tears and wails, necessitating the immediate employment of all the comforting powers of the lord of the flat.

For there lay The Combs — the set of combs, side and back, that Della had worshipped long in a Broadway window. Beautiful combs, pure tortoise shell, with jewelled rims — just the shade to wear in the beautiful vanished hair. They were expensive combs, she knew, and her heart had simply craved and yearned over them without the least hope of possession. And now, they were hers, but the tresses that should have adorned the coveted adornments were gone.

But she hugged them to her bosom, and at length she was able to look up with dim eyes and a smile and say: "My hair grows so fast, Jim!"

And then Della leaped up like a little singed cat and cried, "Oh, oh!"

Jim had not yet seen his beautiful present. She held it out to him eagerly upon her open palm. The dull precious metal seemed to flash with a reflection of her bright and ardent spirit.

"Isn't it a dandy, Jim? I hunted all over town to find it. You'll have to look at the time a hundred times a day now. Give me your watch. I want to see how it looks on it."

Instead of obeying, Jim tumbled down on the couch and put his hands under the back of his head and smiled.

"Dell," said he, "let's put our Christmas presents away and keep 'em a while. They're too nice to use just at present. I sold the watch to get the money to buy your combs. And now suppose you put the chops on."

The magi, as you know, were wise men — wonderfully wise men — who brought gifts to the Babe in the manger. They invented the art of giving Christmas presents. Being wise, their gifts were no doubt wise ones, possibly bearing the privilege of exchange in case of duplication. And here I have lamely related to you the uneventful chronicle of two foolish children in a flat who most unwisely sacrificed for each other the greatest treasures of their house. But in a last word to the wise of these days let it be said that of all who give gifts these two were the wisest. Of all who give and receive gifts, such as they are wisest. Everywhere they are wisest. They are the magi.

➤ Themes

- 1. Love and sacrifice :** Love and sacrifice define the core essence of the story. Jim and Della would be willing to give up something that is more precious to them, which highlights the depth of their love. Their willingness to sacrifice personal desires or wealth for the sake of a loved one shows the essence of love lies in this : the pursuit of happiness over one's needs.
- 2. Irony :** The story is developed on situational irony, wherein the outcomes are the opposite of what the characters and readers would expect. In this case, Jim and Della's gifts are rendered useless by their mutual sacrifices. Still, this is what makes it ironic and profound, for in the end, their love becomes much more precious than the actual gifts they traded.
- 3. The value of gifts :** The story challenges the conventional notion of gift-giving by showing that the worth of a gift lies not in its monetary value but in the thought, effort, and sacrifice behind it. Jim and Della's gifts, though impractical, are rich in symbolic meaning and demonstrate the true spirit of giving.

➤ Character analysis

- 1. Della :** The protagonist of the story is Della, whom the story is primarily told from. She is young and faithful, with deep passion for her husband Jim. Her love for Jim is obvious as she comes to find solace in him when things seem unbearable. She is unable to afford a worthwhile gift for Christmas; she saves pennies and manages to save only \$1.87 in a year. Her most prized possession was her long beautiful hair, and she sells that in a symbolic gesture to purchase a special watch chain for Jim.
- 2. Jim :** Jim, Della's husband, is a 22-year-old who bears the weight of keeping his small household running on meager money. But despite these hardships, Jim is cool, considerate, and loving toward Della. This love is manifested in the self-sacrifice he does for Della; he sells the valuable family heirloom gold watch to raise money for the combs and ornaments for her hair.
- 3. Madame Sofronie :** Madame Sofronie is the proprietor of the hair store where Della sells her locks. She is depicted as a businesslike and practical woman, with a presence described as large and somewhat impersonal. Her exchange with Della is businesslike and to the point as she inspects Della's hair and hands over \$20 without any emotion. While Della is attached to her hair, for Madame Sofronie, it is a commodity to be bartered. This contrast underlines the emotional depth of Della and Jim's sacrifices compared to Madame Sofronie's detached perspective.

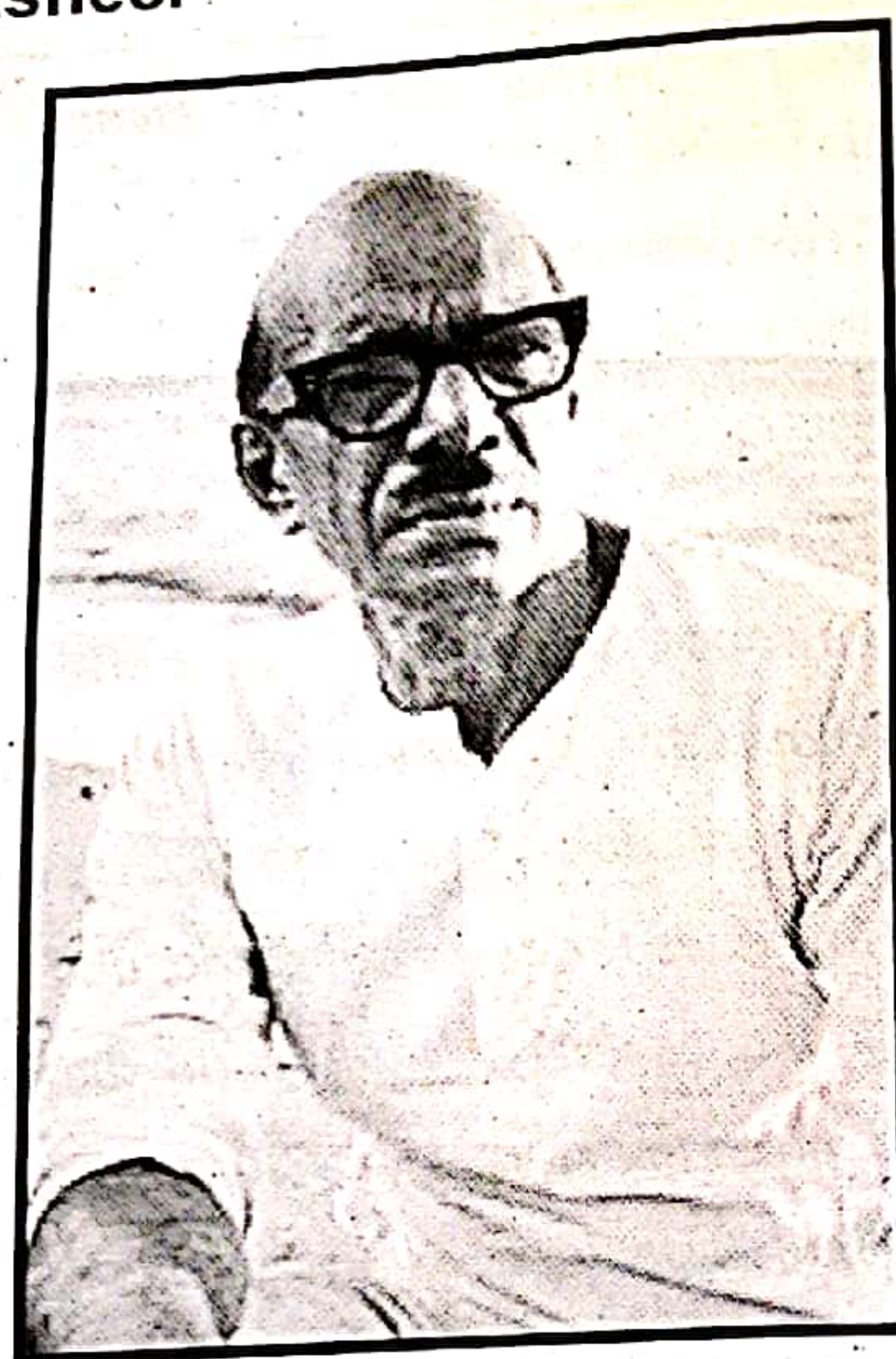
Review Questions

1. What is the real name of O. Henry's, and what are some of his life experiences that influenced his writing ?
2. Write two other famous stories written by O. Henry.
3. What is a defining characteristic of O. Henry's stories ?
4. What is the financial situation of Jim and Della in the story ?
5. What are the two prized possessions of the Dillingham Youngs ?
6. Why does Della sell her hair, and what does she buy with the money ?
7. What is Jim's reaction when he sees Della's short hair ?
8. What gift does Jim buy for Della, and how did he afford it ?
9. How does the story conclude, and what do the characters realize about their gifts ?
10. How does the story depict the themes of love and sacrifice ?
11. Explain the irony in the story's ending.
12. What message does the story convey about the true value of gifts ?
13. In your opinion, were Jim and Della foolish or wise in their actions? Why ?
14. How would the story be different if the characters hadn't made their sacrifices ?
15. What does the comparison of Jim and Della to the Magi symbolize ?
16. How does Della show her love and devotion to Jim ?
17. What qualities of Jim make him a good husband ?
18. Do you think Della's act of cutting her hair was impulsive or thoughtful ? Why ?
19. Identify examples of O. Henry's use of vivid descriptions in the story.
20. What is the role of humor in O. Henry's storytelling ?

6.3 The World-Renowned Nose by V.M. Basheer

About the Author

Vaikom Muhammad Basheer (1908-1994), popularly known as the "Beypore Sultan," was an Indian writer who revolutionized Malayalam literature with his simple yet profound storytelling. Born on January 21, 1908, in Thalayolaparambu, Kottayam, Kerala, Basheer grew up in a modest household and later became one of the most celebrated figures in Indian literature. His works are based deep in human experience, tackling socio-political issues and societal anomalies with a very unique blend of wit, satire, and realism.



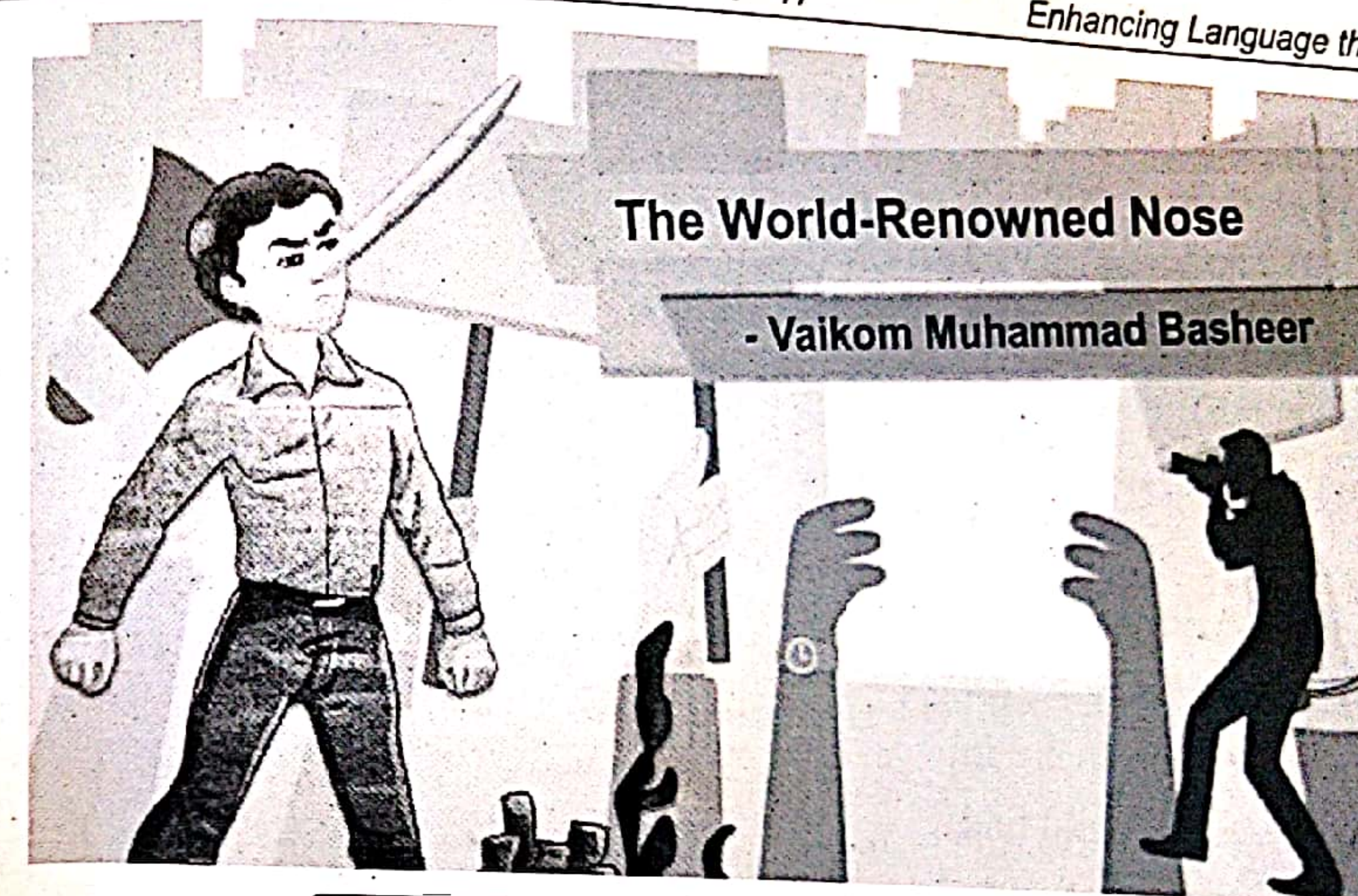
Vaikom Muhammad Basheer

Basheer's narrative styles are humorous yet easily accessible with which he writes against the tide of conventional traditions and explores in tales like the one about "The World-Renowned Nose", themes from love, poverty to caste and hypocrisy making his own writing timeless and inspiring.

A freedom fighter, advocate for social change, Basheer sparked an awareness regarding various issues with the help of his writings. He spent several years wandering about, meeting people, which added layers of richness to his stories; today, his memory is etched forever as a giant literary figure and as a commoner's voice in the Malayalam world.

➤ Summary of The World-Renowned Nose

The World-Renowned Nose, a comical and satirical story by V. M. Basheer, explores vanity and societal perception through the character of a man who is recognized primarily because of an unusually large nose on his face. While the nose is strange-looking, both to the protagonist and society at large, it takes an absurd level of importance as an identity and symbol of pride for that man. The humor is in the overemphasis on a trivial aspect of the man's appearance, which reveals the superficiality and absurdities of societal values.



The World-Renowned Nose full story

It is a startling piece of news. That nose has become a matter of dispute among intellectuals.

I record here the true story of that nose.

The owner of that world-renowned nose had completed twenty-four years of age, when the story began. No one knew him before that. Does the twenty-fourth year in a person's life have any special significance? Who knows? If one looks through the recorded pages of world history one finds that the twenty-fourth year had a significance in many great lives. Students of history need hardly be told this.

The hero of our story was a cook, a kitchen worker if you like. He was not particularly intelligent. He could not read and write. His world was confined to the kitchen. He was totally indifferent to happenings outside the kitchen. Why should he pay attention to them? He could eat to his satisfaction; sleep; work. His daily routine was confined to these activities.

He did not know the names of the months of the year. When it was time for him to receive his salary his mother would come and take it. He lived a contented life till he reached his twenty-fourth year. Then an amazing thing happened!

His nose grew slightly in length. It passed his mouth and reached the level of his chin.

The nose began to grow in length every day. Within a month the nose reached his navel. Did he feel uncomfortable? Not in the least! He could breathe freely. He could distinguish between smells.

However, because of his nose, the poor cook was dismissed from service.

What was the reason?

No group came forward with the battle cry: 'Take back the dismissed employee.' Political parties shut their eyes to this piece of rank injustice. No lover of humanity came forward to help.

The poor cook! No one had to tell him why he had lost his job. The reason was that the people living in the house where he worked could find no peace or quiet because of him. People came visiting night and day, to see the long-nosed one. Photographers pestered them. News reporters became a nuisance. A number of things were pilfered from the house.

As the dismissed cook sat starving in his lowly hut, he was convinced of one thing: his nose had acquired great publicity!

People from distant lands came to see him. They stood stunned with surprise at his long nose. Some touched it too. But no one asked: 'Have you eaten today? Why do you look so weak?' There was no money in the hut. Was he a wild animal to be kept starving? He might be a fool, but he was a human being. One day he called his old mother aside and told her in a whisper: 'Get these horrid people out!'

The mother promptly put them all out and closed the door.

Good fortune dawned on the mother and son after that day! People began to bribe the mother to see the son's nose! Some upholders of justice protested against this corruption. But the Government did not take any action. Many protested against the inaction of the Government and joined revolutionary parties, out to sabotage the Government!

The income of the long-nosed one grew day by day. In six years the poor cook became a millionaire.

He acted thrice in films. What vast audiences were attracted by the technicolour feature film: 'The Human Submarine'! Six poets wrote epic poems about the noble qualities of the long-nosed one! Nine well-known writers wrote biographies of the long-nosed one and won wealth and acclaim.



His princely abode was also a guest house open to all. Anyone at any time could get a meal there.

He had two secretaries. Both of them loved the long-nosed one. Both of them worshipped him. When two beautiful females love the same person at the same time, there is bound to be trouble. Troubles came into the life of the long-nosed one.

Other people also loved the long-nosed one. That long nose reaching down to the navel was considered a sign of greatness. The long-nosed one gave his opinion on important world events. Newspapers published his comments:

'An aeroplane with a speed of 10,000 miles an hour has been built! The long-nosed one commented thus on the event ...!'

'Doctor Bundrose Furasiburose has brought a dead man to life! The long-nosed one made the following speech about it ...!'

When people heard that the highest peak in the world had been scaled, they asked; 'What does the long-nosed one say about this?'

If the long-nosed one said nothing about an event ... Phoo! It was unimportant. And so the long-nosed one was expected to comment about anything and everything! Painting, the watch trade, the soul, publishing houses, life after death, the conduct of newspapers, hunting.

It was at this time that conspiracies were hatched to capture the long-nosed one. Capturing something, taking something by physical conquest, was nothing new. The major part of world history consists of conquests and captures.

First of all, it was the Government that made an attempt to capture the long-nosed one. They tried a confidence trick. The Government awarded him the title 'Chief among the long-nosed ones' and gave him a medal. It was the President himself who tied the bejeweled gold medal round the neck of the long-nosed one. Then, instead of shaking the long-nosed one by the hand, the President tweaked the tip of the long nose. This was filmed by newsreel cameramen and shown in all theatres.



By that time the political parties in the country came forward enthusiastically. Comrade Long-Nose must give leadership to the people's struggle! Comrade Long Nose indeed! Whose Comrade? Comrade in what? God! Poor long-nosed one!

The long-nosed one must join the Party! Which party? There were many parties. How would the long-nosed one join different parties at the same time?

The long-nosed one said in his own tongue, 'Why should I join party and parties? Me, I am too tired.'

'Should I join any party?' the long-nosed one asked one of his secretaries, She said: 'Why should you?'

By that time one of the political parties had come out with the slogan, 'Out party is the long-nosed one's party, the long-nosed one's party is the people's party!'

Members of other parties were incensed by this. They got at one of the secretaries and made her issue a scathing statement against the long-nosed one; 'The long-nosed one has deceived the people! He has been cheating them all this while. He has made me a partner in this fraud. Let me declare the truth to the public: the long nose is made of rubber!'

Wow!!! All the newspapers splashed the news on their front pages. The nose of the long-nosed one is made of rubber!

Would the people keep quiet at this? Would they not react in anger? Cables, telephone calls, letters from all parts of the world! The President was allowed no peace or quiet. 'Destruction to the rubber nose of the long-nosed one! Down with the long-nose party! Long live revolution!'

When the anti-long-nose party put out this statement, the opposing party made the other secretary issue a counter statement: 'Beloved countrymen, citizens! What she has said is a lie. She was trying to keep for herself the wealth and good name of Comrade Long-Nose. One of her brothers is in the opposite party. Let me reveal the true colours of the members of the other party. I am the faithful secretary of Comrade Long-Nose. I know for a fact that the nose of the Comrade is not made of rubber. It is as real as my own heart beating inside me. Long live the members of the party supporting Comrade Long-Nose! Long live revolution!'

What was to be done? There was confusion in the minds of the people. The leaders of the party against the long-nosed one began finding fault with the President and the Government: 'Stupid Government! They gave the title of "Chief among the long-nosed ones" to the deceiver of the people. They gave him a gold medal. The President is also party to this fraud. There is betrayal of national interest in all this. The President must resign. The Ministry must resign! The rubber-nosed one must be killed!'

The President reacted angrily. One morning the army and their tanks surrounded the house of the poor long-nosed one. He was arrested and taken away.

There was no news of the long-nosed one for some time. The people forgot about his existence. Then came fresh news with the impact of a nuclear bomb! Do you know what happened? Just when the People had forgotten everything came a brief announcement from the President: 'The trial of the "Chief of the long-nosed ones" will take place on March 9th. Expert doctors who come as representatives of 48 countries will examine him. All the newspapers of the world will be represented. The proceedings will be filmed. People must keep calm.'

People are people. They could not keep calm. They came in large numbers into the metropolis. They invaded the hotels. They burnt public conveyances. They set fire to police stations. They destroyed government buildings.

March 9, eleven a.m. The square in front of the Presidential Palace was a vast sea of humanity. The loud speakers blared forth : 'People must be disciplined. The examination has begun!'

The doctors surrounded the long-nosed one in the presence of the President and cabinet ministers. One doctor blocked the nostrils of the long-nosed one; he immediately opened his mouth wide. Another doctor took a needle and punctured the tip of his nose. To his amazement a drop of blood appeared at the tip of the nose.



The doctors gave their unanimous verdict : 'The nose is genuine.'

One of the female secretaries kissed the long-nosed on the tip of the nose.

'Long live Comrade Long-Nose! Long live the Chief of the long-nosed one! Long live the progressive People's Party of the long-nosed one!'

As this shouting and revelry ended the President thought of another gimmick. He nominated the long-nosed one as a member of parliament! That was the end of it all.

But the parties of which the long-nosed one was not a member formed a United Front and began to say: 'The ministry must resign!'

Look at the way falsehood was being perpetuated! Would there not be confusion of thought? What would the poor intellectuals do?

➤ Themes

1. **Vanity** : The protagonist's pride in his odd nose is a universal human tendency to overemphasize the importance of physical features or some other minute aspects of oneself.
2. **Social perception** : The story satirically laughs at how society tends to elevate inconsequential traits to an undue position and turns them into objects of wonder or worship.
3. **Irony and humor** : The story humorously mocks the societal norms and the self-importance of the protagonist by interweaving irony and humor into its message.

➤ Character analysis

1. **The protagonist** : He is a man who prides himself immensely on his great nose and the fame and glory that it has brought him. He represents human vanity and how minor attributes tend to define people.
2. **Society** : Society plays an enabling role throughout this story, making the nose of the protagonist much more significant, in addition to his inflated sense of ego. This is how collective behavior often pits societal values where superfluous qualities are valued more than meaningful qualities.

Review Questions

1. Who was Vaikom Muhammad Basheer, and what is the story behind him being called the "Beypore Sultan"?
2. How did Basheer's experiences as a wanderer influence his writing?
3. What are the most recurring themes in Basheer's novels?
4. What makes the protagonist's nose unique, and why is it significant in the story?
5. How does society react to the protagonist's nose?
6. What is ironic about the protagonist's pride in his nose?
7. How does the story explore the relationship between the protagonist and society?
8. How does the story satirize vanity and societal values?
9. What does the protagonist's attachment to his nose suggest about human tendencies?
10. How does the story critique the way society elevates trivial aspects of a person?

11. Do you think the protagonist's pride in his nose is justified? Why or why not?
12. How would you interpret the significance of the protagonist's nose as a metaphor?
13. If the protagonist's nose were not unique, how might his identity in the story change?
14. What traits of the protagonist stand out, apart from his nose?
15. How does society contribute to the protagonist's inflated sense of ego?
16. What does the protagonist's relationship with his nose reveal about his personality?
17. What role does irony play in the story's humor?
18. How does Basheer use humor to criticize societal behavior?
19. Can the humor in the story be considered timeless? Why or why not?
20. Identify examples of satire in the story and explain their significance.
21. How does Basheer's simple yet profound storytelling style enhance the impact of the story?

6.4 The Lady or, The Tiger? by Frank R. Stockton

About the Author

Frank R. Stockton was an American writer and humorist, best known for his children's fairy tales, which are still read in schools today. Born in 1834 in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, Stockton wrote against his father's wishes, who was a Methodist minister. He was a wood engraver early in life but later became a writer. After marriage and relocation to New Jersey, he started writing literary pieces but continued working in other jobs for his income.



Frank R. Stockton

Stockton returned to Philadelphia, where his brother, a newspaper editor, published his work. He wrote for The Riverside Magazine and edited *Hearth and Home* and *St. Nicholas Magazine*. Stockton's peculiar style of narration brought him much acclaim, and his stories were rediscovered in the 1960s by the famous illustrator Maurice Sendak, who even won the Lewis Carroll Shelf Award for one of his stories in 1963. He died in Washington, D.C., in 1902 at the age of 68, leaving behind some of the most timeless stories and humor.

➤ Summary of The Lady or, The Tiger?

The story revolves around a half-barbaric king who dispenses justice through a trial of chance in his arena, where an accused has to choose between two doors: one concealing a tiger that guarantees death and the other hiding a lady, resulting in immediate marriage. When the king finds out about his daughter's secret romance with a commoner, he subjects the young man to this trial. The princess knows what is behind each door, and she beckons her lover to pick one, but the story ends on an ambiguous note, leaving readers wondering about his fate or hers.



The Lady or, The Tiger? full story

The story begins with a description of a king who ruled long ago. The king is somewhat barbaric in his rule, but he is also calm and genial to his subjects. Only slightly influenced by the Romans, who ruled nearby, this king did not have gladiator battles or killings of religious prisoners in his amphitheater to amuse his subjects. Instead, this king conducted criminal trials there, and in a very distinctive way. These trials were very popular in his kingdom.

The king's amphitheater contained two doors. Behind one door was a tiger, and behind the other was a lady. Whenever a man was accused of committing a crime, he was sent into the amphitheater to choose one of the two doors. If he chose the door with the tiger behind it, he died a gruesome death at its claws and teeth, and was therefore deemed guilty of the crime. If he chose the door with the lady, he was deemed innocent and was married to the lady then and there by a waiting priest. It didn't matter if the man was already married, since the king demanded his own form of reward be enacted regardless of the newly innocent man's circumstances.

At a certain time, the king becomes aware of a scandal involving his own daughter, the princess, and he finds that she is engaged in a love affair with a young man of low social standing. In the king's eyes, this is a crime of the highest order, and he demands the trial of her lover in the usual fashion. This time, the most ferocious tiger that could be found is put behind one door, and the most beautiful lady in the kingdom behind the other. The crowds are massive, and even those who cannot gain access to the amphitheater press inward to catch a glimpse of the trial.

The princess, being in love with the young man on trial, has discovered which door holds the tiger and which holds the lady. She also knows that the lady is one from the king's court, and one whom she hates for her amorous attention to the princess's lover. The princess becomes viciously jealous at the thought of the woman anxiously awaiting her marriage to the young man.

At the trial, the young man enters the amphitheater in the usual way and bows to the king. But as he does so, he looks to the princess for some kind of sign about which door he should choose, suspecting that she has used her influence to find out which door holds which fate. The princess makes a quick gesture to the right, and the young man goes directly to open the door on the right. But it is not known which fate the princess has chosen for him and for herself. On the one hand, she may have saved his life but also condemned herself to endure the heartbreak of seeing him happily married to another woman. On the other hand, she may have chosen his brutal death, which they will both suffer through but will eventually enjoy a reunion in the afterlife.

➤ Themes

1. **Jealousy vs. Love** : The internal conflict of the princess, which is her love for her lover and her jealousy towards the lady, makes it a very human emotion. In the end, it depends on whether her jealousy or love takes over her decision, which makes her character both relatable and flawed.
2. **Justice and morality** : The king's justice system is a commentary on the subjectivity and arbitrariness of power. It questions the question of fairness, morality, and ethics in punishment.
3. **Ambiguity** : The open ending is a central theme, making the reader deeply engage with the story. The narrative invites interpretation, reflecting the complexity of moral dilemmas and human psychology.

➤ Character analysis

1. **The king** : The king is a half-barbarous ruler who has absolute power in his kingdom. He is shown to be amicable and benevolent towards his subjects, but his sense of justice is arbitrary and theatrical. He forms an amphitheater-based trial system where the fate of an accused person is decided by their choice between two doors: one contains a tiger, which leads to death, and the other contains a lady, which leads to marriage. The king believes in this system because he loves control and spectacle rather than fairness or morality. His partially barbaric nature comes out in his enjoyment of the entertainment value of these trials, while his partially civilized side is reflected in his desire to maintain order and justice in his kingdom — though in his own eccentric way.
2. **The princess** : The princess is the king's daughter and has a major place in the novel. She acquires her father's half-barbarous character, which both makes her hot-blooded and prone to mood swings. Her love for the youth is absolute, but showing her terrific jealousy at the thought of his marriage with some other woman exposes her darker nature. In a desperate situation, when the princess has the choice to decide whether her lover should live or die, she reveals the mystery behind every door that would decide her lover's future. Her inner turmoil — whether to save him and let him marry another woman or to send him to his death — propels the story into tension. Her character depicts the complexity of love, jealousy, and the ambiguity of morality that makes her one of the most enigmatic characters in the story.
3. **The young man** : The young man is the princess's lover and very handsome, charming, but of a lowly class to suit a suitor for a princess. His love for the princess is genuine, but his destiny is left to her sole discretion. He trusts her deeply, looking to her for

guidance during his trial, unaware of her internal struggle. As a character, the young man symbolizes vulnerability, as he is at the mercy of both the king's cruel justice system and the princess's emotions. His ultimate fate remains unknown, adding to the story's enduring mystery.

Review Questions

1. Who was Frank R. Stockton, and what is he best known for?
2. How did Stockton's career as a wood engraver influence his later work as a writer?
3. Describe the king's unique justice system. How does it work?
4. What crime is the young man accused of, and why does the king consider it severe?
5. How does the princess uncover the secret of the two doors?
6. How does the story relate jealousy to love?
6. What comment does the story make on justice and morality?
7. How does the story's ambiguous ending contribute to its overall theme of human psychology and decision-making?
9. How does the king's personality reflect the balance between barbarism and civilization?
10. What traits of the princess show that she has inherited her father's half-barbarous nature?
11. Do you think the princess chose the lady or the tiger for her lover? Why?
12. If you were the young man, how would you feel about relying on the princess's decision?
13. How might the story be different if the princess and the young man had switched roles?
14. Is the king's justice system really fair? Why or why not?
15. What does the story suggest about human nature and the complexity of emotions like love and jealousy?
16. Why do you think Stockton chose to leave the ending of the story unresolved?
17. How does the open ending encourage readers to reflect on their own moral beliefs?
18. How does Stockton use irony to critique the king's sense of justice?
19. What role does suspense play in the story, and how does it build tension?

